

The Karpman Drama Triangle

Most people can point to a relationship where they feel wronged, or unfairly blamed, or endlessly needed by someone else. Stephen Karpman's Drama Triangle explains why those three positions, Victim, Persecutor and Rescuer, keep recurring across very different relationships, and why moving from one corner to another rarely settles anything. This workbook teaches the model in full and asks you to trace one real relationship of your own through all three corners of it.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to use this workbook



This workbook is a standalone resource. It teaches the model in full, so you can work through it whether or not you have watched the lecture it came from.

It asks you to write, not just read.

Before you begin, choose one relationship, past or present, where you have felt cast as the one who was wronged, the one who was blamed, or the one who was needed to fix things. You will carry that one relationship through the exercise.

Write it here, so you have it to hand

This Achology workbook is designed to accompany lecture 30 of the
Cognitive Behavioural Therapy (CBT) Practitioner Course

It will still be insightful for those not enrolled in this course.



The teaching

Karpman's Drama Triangle names three positions people habitually occupy inside troubled relationships: the Victim, the Persecutor, and the Rescuer. Stephen Karpman first described the model in 1968, working in the field of transactional analysis. He later set it out in full in his book *A Game Free Life*.

The claim underneath it is simple and slightly uncomfortable. A great deal of relational conflict is not really about the issue on the table. It is one or more people performing roles that nobody actually assigned to them.

The Victim experiences life as something done to them: by circumstance, by other people, by an unfair past. The felt sense is "you don't understand what this is like for me." This is not the same as having genuinely been wronged, which happens to everyone. It is the habit of reading events as proof that one is powerless to do anything about them.

The Persecutor is the figure a Victim story requires. Someone, or something, has to be at fault for the Victim position to make sense. The two positions complete each other. Every "this was done to me" implicitly names a "because of them."

The Rescuer is the hardest of the three to recognise from the inside. A Rescuer needs to be needed. Their sense of worth comes from fixing, healing, or saving someone else. This feels generous even while it is quietly self-serving, because a Rescuer whose help stops being wanted has lost the role that was holding them up.

None of the three positions holds still. A Rescuer who cannot fix the problem they took on can become, in the other person's eyes, the next Persecutor.

A Victim who is helped without asking can come to resent the Rescuer for the same reason. People rarely stay in one corner, and they rotate sometimes within a single conversation.

Picture a congregation gathering week after week to hear one speaker deliver an address with great conviction. The room takes notes as though every sentence carried unusual weight. Looked at through the triangle, something more specific than admiration is happening.

The congregation has been cast, or has cast itself, as people who cannot manage without guidance. The speaker occupies the Rescuer position, needing an audience that keeps needing him. Neither side would likely describe it that way; the triangle usually operates beneath the level anyone would name out loud.

The practical use of the model is not to work out who the real villain is in a given relationship. That question usually has no stable answer, because the roles move. Its use is to notice which corner you are standing in right now, and to ask what is keeping you there.

Karpman's own suggestion, worked out across *A Game Free Life*, is that none of the three positions is required. A person can decline all three at once: acknowledge a genuine difficulty without blaming it entirely outward, offer help without needing it to be wanted, and hold someone responsible without needing them to be a villain.



The exercise

Take the relationship you chose at the start and carry it through the three positions, in the order the teaching set out. Write in full sentences. Nobody else reads this.

Start with the relationship you chose, and the story as you currently hold it. Describe what has been happening, name which of the three positions, Victim, Persecutor or Rescuer, you have felt yourself standing in most often, and score how strongly that feels true, from one to ten.

How certain do you feel about that conclusion? ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐ 7 ☐ 8 ☐ 9 ☐ 10

Now name the other side of it. Every Victim story implies a Persecutor; every Rescuer needs someone who needs rescuing. Who else is in this story, and which corner does your own account of it put them in?

Test the completing role. If the other person were removed from the story entirely, replaced by simple bad luck or an ordinary disagreement, would your account still make sense? What does keeping them in that corner do for the story?

Notice the rotation. Has your own position in this relationship shifted over time, even within a single conversation? Write down one moment where you moved from one corner to another.

Come back to the story. Rewrite it in three or four sentences, describing what happened without assigning any of the three roles: not injured, not to blame, not needed. Then rescore how certain you feel about your original account, from one to ten.

Rescore your certainty now.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐ 7 ☐ 8 ☐ 9 ☐ 10

Write one thing you could decline next time this pattern starts. Not fixing the relationship, just declining the specific role, Victim, Persecutor or Rescuer, the next time it is offered to you.



Questions for discussion

Work through these questions independently if you must, but they are generally more beneficial when discussed rather than just answered in a workbook. If you are part of the [Achology learning community](#), consider using these questions to start a new forum discussion, or invite others to join a call to discuss them in person.

1. Karpman's model implies a genuine victim of real wrongdoing and someone simply occupying the Victim position can look identical from outside. Is there an actual difference, or only a difference in what happens next?
2. If a Rescuer's motive is partly about their own need to be needed, does that make the help they give less real to the person receiving it?
3. Can a Persecutor be right, in the ordinary sense, and still be occupying that corner of the triangle?
4. Is it possible to recognise your own position in the triangle from inside it, or does that always take someone else's account of the same events?
5. Karpman's own claim is that a relationship free of all three roles is achievable. Does that match what you have actually seen, or does something like this pattern show up in every close relationship eventually?
6. If naming the pattern out loud, inside a relationship, changes how it plays out, does that mean the triangle was ever really about the other person at all?

KNOW YOUR PSYCHOLOGY

Want to take this further with other people?

You've done thinking on your own, and that is the hard part. What's missing is someone else who sees the same topic differently.

Inside the Achology learning community, this is what members do with a resource like this one. Here are two ways to get started.

Discuss this topic in the forum

Post the theme of this workbook and say what you learned working through it. You don't need to prepare anything: the questions are already written to be discussed, and everyone reading has the same context that you do.

Discuss this topic in a group call

Invite other Achology members to a live video call and talk the discussion questions through together. An hour is often more than enough. One person reads a question out, and the conversation does the rest.

[Join the Achology community](#)

The Achology community welcomes everyone interested in this topic. If you haven't participated yet, this is the place where these conversations take place.